

Tennis Pro

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A cheating
girlfriend
loses control

Part I

JJ Vale



The Tennis Pro

A cheating girlfriend's sexual awakening

JJ Vale

PMI

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I wasn't even supposed to be there that afternoon.

The tennis club sat at the edge of the corporate park where Jason worked, all white stucco and terracotta tiles, with courts tucked behind a privacy hedge that blocked out the highway noise. He'd texted me twice that morning asking me to bring his laptop charger, he'd left it at my apartment after staying over I'd said yes without thinking, the way I always did. It was Tuesday. I had the day off. It wasn't a problem.

Except when I got there, the front desk told me he was on a service call somewhere in the building, unreachable for another twenty minutes. They offered to hold the charger for him. I should have said yes. I should have left it there and driven home.

Instead, I told them I'd wait.

I wandered through the lobby past the pro shop with its racks of expensive athletic wear out onto the deck overlooking the courts. Most of them were empty. The afternoon heat had driven everyone inside or into the shade of the pavilion bar where I could hear the low hum of conversation and the clink of glasses. I leaned against the railing and felt the sun press against my shoulders through my thin cotton dress that was when I saw him.

He was alone on the farthest court, hitting serves with a methodical precision that made each motion look effortless. His skin gleamed under the sunlight, dark and smooth, his shoulders and arms carved with the kind of muscle that came from years of work rather than posing in a gym mirror. He wore black athletic shorts and a white shirt that clung to his torso as he moved. I watched him toss the ball, watched the way his body coiled and released, the crack of his racket against the ball sharp and clean.

I didn't realize I was staring until he turned his head and looked directly at me.

I should have looked away. That would have been the normal thing to do. Instead, I stayed exactly where I was, my hands resting on the railing met

his gaze back. It was totally out of character for me. I have no idea what I was thinking.

He paused, racket in hand then gestured toward the gate at the side of the court. An invitation, or maybe a question? I hesitated for a moment before I walked down the steps and across the clay surface, my sandals kicking up small clouds of red dust. What was I thinking?

"Lost?" he asked when I came close enough to hear him without shouting. His voice was low and direct, the kind of voice that didn't waste words.

"No," I said. "Just waiting for someone."

He tilted his head slightly, studying me. "You picked an odd spot to wait."

"The deck has a better view."

"Of what?"

I should have said the courts. I should have said the landscaping or the trees or anything neutral and forgettable. Instead, I said. . . ."You." I pursed my lips but it was too late, the word was out there.

The corner of his mouth twitched into not quite a smile. He bounced the tennis ball once against the clay, caught it then looked at me again. "You play?"

"No, hardly."

"Then you were just watching."

It wasn't a question. I felt something shift in my chest, a small flicker of heat that I didn't expect. "I didn't say I wasn't."

He set the racket down and walked a few steps closer. He was taller than I'd thought, broad through the chest and shoulders there was a kind of stillness to the way he moved, as though he didn't need to rush because he already knew where things were going. I should have stepped back. But I didn't. I held my ground, though he filled the space in front of me completely.

"You're here with someone?" he asked.

"My boyfriend works here. IT contract."

"That's not what I asked, is it."

I blinked. "He's in the building somewhere. I'm waiting for him."

"So you're alone at the moment."

The way he said it wasn't suggestive, exactly. It was observational. Factual. And yet I felt my pulse quicken, felt the heat spread from my chest

up into my throat. I tucked a strand of hair behind my ear, a nervous habit I'd always had tried to keep my voice steady. "For now."

He nodded slowly as though I'd confirmed something he'd already suspected. "What's your name?"

"Claire."

"Isaiah." He didn't offer his hand. He just stood there, watching me with an intensity that made me hyper-aware of the space between us, the way the sun felt on my skin, the faint sound of my own breathing. "You always this direct, Claire?"

The question caught me off guard. I wasn't a direct kind of girl, I was the opposite of direct. I was the person who apologized when someone else bumped into me, who agreed to things I didn't want to do because saying no felt too confrontational. But standing there, with the clay dust settling around my feet and his dark eyes fixed on me, I felt something unfamiliar rise up in my chest.

"I don't know," I said. "Maybe I am." I seriously didn't know.

His eyebrows lifted slightly, surprise flickering across his face. Then he smiled, but just a little. "Interesting."

I should have asked what he meant. I should have made some polite comment and walked away. Instead, I stepped closer, close enough that I could see the faint sheen of sweat on his collarbone, the way his chest rose and fell with each breath. "You have good form," I said.

"Yeah?"

"Your serve. It's clean."

He studied me for a long moment and I saw the exact second when his expression shifted, when he realized I wasn't just making conversation. "You were watching that closely?"

"I told you. I'm always watching."

He laughed, a short, surprised sound. "You're something else," he said and he half turned away.

I didn't know what to say to that, so I said nothing. My heart was hammering now, a wild, erratic rhythm that made my hands feel shaky. I curled my fingers into fists at my sides trying to anchor myself, but it didn't help. I felt untethered, like I'd stepped outside my own body and was watching someone else stand here, saying these things, holding his gaze without flinching.

"Your boyfriend know you talk to strange men like this?" Isaiah asked.

"Like what?"

"Like you're daring me to say something back."

My breath caught. I wanted to deny it, to tell him he was wrong, but the words wouldn't come. Because he wasn't wrong. I didn't know why I was doing this, didn't know where this version of myself had come from, but I could feel her now, bold and reckless and utterly unfamiliar.

"I'm not daring you to do anything," I said, even though we both knew it was a lie.

He took a step closer. Not enough to touch me, but enough that I had to tilt my head back to keep looking at him. "You sure about that?"

I should have said yes. I should have laughed it off, made a joke, stepped away. But I didn't. I just stood there, feeling the heat radiate off his body, feeling the way my own skin prickled with awareness I realized with a sharp, dizzying clarity that I didn't want to step away.

"I should go," I said.

"Should you?"

"Jason's probably done by now."

Isaiah didn't move. "Probably."

Neither of us moved. The space between us felt charged, electric, like the air before a thunderstorm. I could hear my own heartbeat in my ears, could feel the way my dress clung to my skin in the heat. I didn't know what I was doing. I didn't know who I was anymore.

"You're going to run," he said quietly. It wasn't a question.

"I'm not running."

"Then what are you doing?"

I met his eyes for a moment, I didn't have an answer. Then I said, softly. . . "I don't know."

He smiled, slow and knowing I felt something twist deep in my stomach. "Yeah," he said. "You do."

I turned and walked away before I could say anything else, before I could let that strange, new and wild and reckless version of myself pull me any further out of bounds. But even as I crossed the court and climbed the steps back to the deck, I could feel his eyes on me, heavy and certain I knew with absolute clarity that I was going to come back.

I made it halfway to the parking lot before I realized I was still holding Jason's charger.

My hands were shaking. Not obviously, not enough that anyone watching would notice, but enough that I had to stop and press my palms flat against the hood of my car, feeling the heat of the metal seep into my skin. The sun was relentlessly beating down on the asphalt, but I felt cold everywhere except where Isaiah had looked at me.

I forced myself to breathe slowly, to think clearly. I would go back inside. I would leave the charger at the desk. I would text Jason that I'd dropped it off. I would drive home and this would be nothing, just a strange moment I could file away and forget about.

Except I didn't want to forget it.

That was the part that frightened me the most. Not what had happened, but how much I wanted it to happen again.

I pushed away from the car and walked back toward the entrance, my sandals clicking against the pavement. The lobby was cooler, air-conditioned to the point of being almost uncomfortable. The woman at the desk smiled at me, professional and distant took the charger without comment. I should have left then. The rational part of me, the Claire who had existed until twenty minutes ago, knew that leaving was the only sensible option.

Instead, I heard myself ask. . . . "Is there a bathroom I could use?"

She directed me down a hallway past the pro shop. I thanked her and walked slowly, deliberately, giving myself time to change my mind. But when I reached the bathroom, I didn't go in. I stood in the hallway staring at my reflection in the mirrored wall across from the door.

I looked exactly the same. Pale skin, light brown hair pulled back in a loose ponytail, a simple blue dress that fell to just above my knees. Nothing about my appearance suggested what I'd just done, the way I'd spoken to him, the way I'd stepped closer instead of away. I looked like someone who said "excuse me" too often and never sent back food at restaurants even when it was wrong.

But I didn't feel like that person anymore.

My phone buzzed. Jason.

Got the charger, thanks babe. You already leave?

I typed back quickly. *Yeah, heading home now.*

Another buzz, almost immediate. *You're the best. Love you.*

I stared at his words. He said them easily, casually, the way he said most things. Jason was uncomplicated. He liked his job, liked craft beer and

action movies, liked that I was easy to be around. We'd been together for almost two years in that time, he'd never once looked at me the way Isaiah had looked at me ten minutes ago.

Like he could see something in me even I didn't know was there. But it was.

I put my phone away and walked back toward the lobby, but my feet carried me past the entrance, past the pro shop back out onto the deck. The courts were still mostly empty. The farthest one, where Isaiah had been, was vacant now. I felt a sharp stab of something that might have been disappointment, which was crazy.

Then I saw him. He was standing near the pavilion bar talking to an older white man in expensive tennis whites. The man was gesturing animatedly, clearly telling some story Isaiah was nodding with the kind of polite attention that suggested he'd heard it all before. His eyes flicked toward me for just a fraction of a second, then back to the man.

He'd seen me.

I should have left, of course. I turned toward the parking lot that was when I heard his voice.

"Claire."

Not loud but loud enough. I turned back slowly. Isaiah had excused himself from the conversation and was walking toward me, his movements unhurried and certain. The older man watched him go with mild confusion, then shrugged and headed into the bar.

"Forget something?" Isaiah asked when he reached me.

"No. I just . . . " I trailed off, realizing I didn't have a plausible excuse. "I was just leaving."

"Past tense?"

"I am leaving."

He studied me and I watched his expression shift from neutral curiosity to something more knowing. "You came back out here."

"I was just. . . ."

"You came back," he repeated there was no question in it this time. He knew. He'd known the moment he saw me standing on the deck again. "Why?"

I opened my mouth to deny it, to make up some excuse about needing to call Jason or check something in my car, but the lie wouldn't form. We stood there in the afternoon heat and I felt that same strange boldness rising

in my chest again, the one that had made me say things I never said, that had made me step closer instead of away.

"I don't know," I said finally it was the most honest thing I'd said all day.

Isaiah was quiet for a moment. Then he gestured toward the empty court where we'd spoken before. "You said you don't really play."

"I don't."

"But you know what good form looks like."

"I've watched tennis before."

"That's not the same thing." He started walking toward the court, not looking back to see if I would follow. "Come on."

"I can't."

He stopped and turned. "Why not?"

"I should go home."

"Should." He said the word like it was something fragile, easily broken. "You keep saying that. What do you want to do?"

The question hung between us, simple and impossible. I didn't know how to answer it. I'd spent so much of my life doing what I should do, being who I should be, that I'd never learned to separate obligation from desire. They'd always been the same thing, or close enough that the difference didn't matter.

But standing there, with the sun hot on my shoulders and Isaiah watching me with those dark, patient eyes, I felt the distance between should and want stretch into something vast and unmapped.

"I want . . ." I started, then stopped.

"Yeah?"

"I want to see if I'm any good."

His smile was slow, dangerous. "At tennis?"

My throat felt tight. "Yes."

"Alright then." He continued toward the court this time I followed. My sandals were wrong for clay, I knew that immediately, but I didn't care. He opened the gate and held it for me, a gesture that felt both courteous and somehow possessive, like he was ushering me into territory he controlled.

The court was empty, private, surrounded by the high hedge that blocked the view from the parking lot. Isaiah picked up two rackets from the bench and held one out to me. I took it, feeling the weight of it in my hand, the grip still slightly damp from his palm.

"You ever hold one of these before?" he asked.

"Of course, don't be stupid."

"Show me."

I gripped it the way I remembered, my hand wrapped around the leather he shook his head. "Not like that. Here." He moved behind me, close enough that I could feel the heat radiating from his body reached around to adjust my grip. His hand covered mine, large and warm and strong. "Relax your wrist. You're too tense."

I tried to focus on the racket, on the position of my fingers, but all I could think about was how close he was standing, the way his chest nearly touched my back, the scent of clean sweat and something else, something that might have been cologne or might have just been him.

"Better," he said, his voice low near my ear. He didn't move away. "You feel the difference?"

I nodded, not trusting my voice.

"Now hold it up. Like you're going to hit a forehand." His hand stayed on mine, guiding my arm through the motion. The racket swung through the air, slow and controlled I felt his body move with mine, felt the solid presence of him behind me like a wall I could fall back against if I let myself.

"That's good," he murmured. "You're a fast learner."

I lowered the racket and he finally stepped back, giving me space I didn't want. I turned to face him and found him watching me with an expression I couldn't quite read. Amusement, maybe. Or recognition.

"Your boyfriend play?" he asked.

The question jarred me. "Jason? No. He's not really athletic."

"But you are."

"I didn't say that."

"You didn't have to. I can tell by the way you move. You're aware of your body. That's not something you can fake." He walked to the other side of the net bouncing a tennis ball against the clay. "You ready?"

"For what?"

"To see if you're any good." He grinned I felt something flutter low in my stomach. "I'll go easy on you."

He served the ball gently, a slow lob that arced over the net. I swung and missed completely, nearly dropping the racket. He laughed, not unkindly retrieved another ball.

"Keep your eye on it," he called. "Don't think. Just watch."

The next serve was similar this time I made contact. The ball bounced weakly back over the net, but it went over I felt a small surge of satisfaction. We continued like that, Isaiah feeding me easy shots, me fumbling through returns with increasing desperation. I was terrible. I knew I was terrible. But he didn't seem to care.

"You're overthinking it," he said after I missed three shots in a row. He came around the net toward me. "Tennis is about rhythm, not thought. You have to let your body do what it already knows how to do."

"My body doesn't know anything about tennis."

"It knows more than you think." He stood close to me again I realized he did this deliberately, used proximity the way other people used words. "Try again. This time, don't think about the racket or the ball or anything. Just feel."

He served I watched the ball come toward me. I didn't think about form or technique. I just swung somehow the racket connected solidly, sending the ball back over the net with force I didn't know I had.

Isaiah caught it with his free hand, his eyebrows raised. "See?"

I was breathing hard, adrenaline singing through my veins. "Beginner's luck."

"No." He walked closer, stopping just on my side of the net. "That was something else. That was you getting out of your own way." He paused. "You do that a lot? Get in your own way?"

The question felt too intimate, too knowing. "I don't know what you mean."

"Yeah, you do." He reached out and adjusted the collar of my dress which had twisted during one of my swings. His fingers brushed against my collarbone, light and brief, but I felt it everywhere. "You think too much. I bet you apologize for things that aren't your fault. I bet you say yes when you mean no."

My breath caught. "You don't know anything about me."

"I know you came back when you should have left. I know you're still here." His hand dropped away from my collar but he didn't step back. "I know your boyfriend is somewhere in that building you're out here with me."

"We're just playing tennis."

"Is that what we're doing?"

The air felt thick, heavy with humidity and something else, something unspoken. I could see a bead of sweat trace down the side of his neck, could see the way his chest rose and fell with each breath. I knew I should say something, should break this moment before it became something I couldn't take back.

Instead, I said. . . . "What else would we be doing?"

His smile was slow, knowing. "You tell me, Claire."

My phone buzzed in the small bag I'd left on the bench. We both looked at it, then back at each other. The spell didn't break. If anything, it intensified.

"You should probably get that," Isaiah said.

"Probably."

Neither of us moved. The phone stopped buzzing. The silence that followed felt charged, full of decisions I hadn't made yet but knew I would make eventually.

"Same time tomorrow?" he asked quietly. "If you want to work on your form."

I should have said no. I should have laughed it off, thanked him for the lesson never come back. But that careful, cautious version of myself felt very far away now, replaced by someone I barely recognized but desperately wanted to know better.

"What time?" I heard myself say.

"Two o'clock. I have a break between lessons."

"Okay."

"Okay." He held my gaze for a long moment I saw something in his expression that made my stomach flip. Not triumph exactly, but satisfaction. He'd known I would say yes. He'd known before I did. "See you tomorrow, Claire."

I walked back to my car in a daze, my legs unsteady, my whole body humming with an energy I didn't recognize. When I checked my phone, I found a text from Jason: *What do you want for dinner? I can pick something up on the way home.*

I stared at the message for a long time before I answered. *Anything is fine.*

And then I sat in my car in the tennis club parking lot, my hands gripping the steering wheel tried to understand what I'd just done. What I was about to keep doing.

I didn't understand it. But I knew, with a certainty that felt both terrifying and inevitable, that I would be back.

I told Jason I was meeting my friend Sarah for lunch.

The lie came easily, smoothly, without hesitation. That was what frightened me most, not that I was lying, but how natural it felt. I'd never been good at deception. In college, I'd been unable to keep surprise parties secret, always giving something away with my expression or my tone. But standing in Jason's kitchen that Wednesday morning, watching him pour coffee into his travel mug, I felt nothing but calm certainty.

"That's nice," he said, kissing my forehead. "You should do that more often. You've been kind of out of it lately."

Had I? I hadn't noticed. But I nodded and smiled and told him to have a good day then I stood at the window and watched him drive away, feeling like I was watching a stranger leave.

I had four hours before I needed to be at the tennis club. I showered, taking longer than usual, aware of my body in a way I hadn't been in years. I shaved my legs even though I'd just done it two days ago. I put on lotion that smelled like vanilla and something floral. I chose my underwear carefully, not the practical cotton ones I usually wore, but a matching set in pale pink that Jason had bought me for my birthday and that I'd never worn before, they were too risqué.

I told myself I was being ridiculous. We were just playing tennis. That was all. But my hands shook as I fastened the clasp of my bra when I looked at myself in the mirror, I barely recognized the woman staring back. My cheeks were flushed and my eyes were bright with something that looked dangerously close to excitement.

I arrived at the club at one-ifty-five. The parking lot was fuller today, expensive cars gleaming in the sun. I sat in my car for three minutes, watching the clock on my dashboard tick forward, giving myself time to change my mind. To be sensible. To be the person I'd always been.

At one-ifty-nine, I got out and walked toward the courts.

Isaiah was already there hitting balls against the practice wall with mechanical precision. He was wearing dark blue athletic shorts today and a gray shirt that clung to his shoulders. He saw me approaching and caught the ball mid-bounce, turning to face me with an expression that was somehow both pleased and unsurprised.

"Wasn't sure you'd come," he said, though his tone suggested otherwise.

"I said I would, didn't I?"

"People say a lot of things." He walked toward me I noticed he moved differently when we were alone, more deliberately, like he was giving me time to adjust to his presence. "You ready?"

"I think so."

"You think so." He smiled slightly. "That's honest, at least." He handed me the same racket from yesterday our fingers brushed as I took it. The contact lasted a fraction of a second longer than necessary. "Same rules as yesterday. Don't think. Just feel."

We started with the same easy volleys, him feeding me gentle shots that I returned with varying degrees of success. But today felt different. The air between us was charged with something that hadn't been there yesterday, or maybe it had been there but we were both pretending it wasn't. Today, we weren't pretending.

After about twenty minutes, he called a break. I was breathing hard, sweat dampening my hairline despite the short sleeves of my tennis dress I'd bought that morning at a sporting goods store, telling myself it was practical, not that I wanted him to see my legs. He tossed me a water bottle from the cooler by the bench I caught it clumsily.

"You're getting better," he said, sitting down. "Your form is improving."

I sat beside him, not too close but not as far as I should have. "I'm still terrible."

"You're learning. That's different." He turned to look at me I felt his gaze move over my face, down to my throat, to where my dress had ridden up slightly on my thigh. When his eyes met mine again, there was something in them that made my mouth go dry. "You wore a dress."

It wasn't a question. "It's tennis clothes."

"It's short."

"It's athletic wear."

"Claire." He said my name slowly, deliberately. "Why are you really here?"

My heart was hammering. "To practice."

"Practice what?"

I knew what he was asking. I knew what he wanted me to say. The old Claire, the careful Claire, would have deflected. Would have made a joke or changed the subject or pretended not to understand. But that Claire felt like

someone I used to know, someone I'd left behind in the parking lot yesterday afternoon.

"I don't know yet," I said quietly.

He studied me for a long moment I saw something shift in his expression. A decision being made. "Stand up."

I stood. He stood with me, close enough that I had to tilt my head back to meet his eyes. Close enough that I could see the exact moment he decided to stop being careful.

"You need to work on your stance," he said. "You're too stiff. You need to be loose, flexible." He moved behind me, the way he had yesterday, but this time his hands settled on my hips. Heavy. Warm. Solid. "Bend your knees slightly."

I did his hands moved with me, guiding me into position. His thumbs pressed against the small of my back, just above the waistband of my dress. I felt the heat of his palms through the thin fabric.

"Like this," he murmured, his voice close to my ear. "You need to be able to move quickly in any direction. You need to be ready." His hands slid down slightly, to the tops of my thighs, steadying me. "Feel that? Feel how much more control you have when you're balanced?"

I couldn't speak but I nodded.

"Show me." His hands left my body I felt their absence like a loss. "Move left."

I shifted left he made a small sound of approval. "Good. Now right."

I moved right. He was watching me intently I realized with a sharp thrill that he wasn't watching my feet or my stance. He was watching my legs, the way the dress moved when I moved.

"Again," he said. "Faster."

I moved left, then right, then left again. The dress swayed with each movement, rising higher on my thighs. I saw his jaw tighten.

"You're a fast learner," he said, his voice rougher than before. "I noticed that yesterday. You pick things up quickly when you're motivated."

"I'm motivated."

"I can see that." He moved closer again this time he didn't pretend there was a technical reason. He just stood there, looking down at me I watched him war with something internal. "This is a bad idea."

"What is?"

"You know what."

I did know. I knew exactly what he meant I knew he was right. But knowing something was a bad idea had never stopped anyone from wanting it. "Maybe."

"Your boyfriend. . . ."

"Jason," I said. "His name is Jason."

"Jason," Isaiah repeated. "Does he know you're here?"

"No."

"Does he know how you look at me?"

My breath caught. "How do I look at you?"

He reached out and touched my face, just one finger tracing the line of my jaw. It was the lightest possible touch, barely there, but I felt it in my knees, in my stomach, in places I didn't want to think about. "Like you want me to show you things he's never shown you."

I should have denied it, should have pulled away, should have been offended or shocked or something other than what I was, which was desperately, achingly honest. "What if I do?"

His finger stilled against my jaw. "Claire."

"What if I want that?"

He was quiet for a long moment, his hand still touching my face, his eyes searching mine. Then he said, very softly. . . . "You need to be sure. Because if we start this, I'm not going to be able to stop halfway. And I don't think you are either."

"I'm never sure about anything," I whispered. "I've never been less sure in my life. But I know I can't stop thinking about yesterday. About the way you looked at me. About how I felt when I was here."

"How did you feel?"

"Alive."

The word hung between us, raw and true. His hand moved from my jaw to the back of my neck, his fingers tangling in my hair I watched him make a decision. Watched him stop fighting whatever he'd been fighting.

"Tomorrow," he said. "Two o'clock. But not here."

My pulse was racing. "Where?"

"There's a private court on the other side of the property. The members-only one. No one uses it during the day." His thumb stroked the sensitive skin behind my ear and I felt my eyes start to close. "It's more secluded. More private."

"Okay," I nearly whispered to him

"Claire." He tugged gently on my hair, making me look at him. "You understand what I'm saying?"

I understood. He was telling me that tomorrow would be different. That whatever line we'd been dancing around today, we would cross it tomorrow. That if I showed up at two o'clock at that private court, I would be making a choice I couldn't unmake.

"I understand," I said.

He held my gaze for another long moment, then released my hair and stepped back. The sudden absence of his touch felt like cold water. "You should go. Before I forget we're in public."

I picked up my bag with shaking hands, barely able to coordinate my movements. As I walked toward the gate, I heard him say my name one more time. I turned back.

He was standing in the middle of the court, racket in hand, looking at me with an intensity that made my stomach flip. "Wear the dress again."

It wasn't a request. It was an instruction, one that promised exactly what would happen if I obeyed. I nodded, not trusting my voice walked away before I could do something reckless like walk back to him.

I sat in my car for ten minutes before I felt steady enough to drive. My whole body was humming, alive with an anticipation that felt both terrifying and inevitable. I looked at myself in the rearview mirror and barely recognized the woman looking back. My lips were parted, my cheeks flushed, my eyes bright with something that looked like hunger.

Tomorrow. Two o'clock. The private court.

I started the car and drove home to Jason, who would ask how lunch with Sarah was, who would kiss me absently while checking his phone, who would never think to wonder why I'd showered again the moment I got home. Who would never know that the woman he said goodnight to wasn't the same woman who had said goodbye to him that morning.

Because she wasn't. And tomorrow at two o'clock, I was going to find out exactly who I was becoming.

I woke up at six in the morning, two hours before Jason's alarm, my body already tense with anticipation. He was asleep beside me, one arm thrown across my stomach, his breathing deep and even. I lay still, staring at the ceiling, feeling the weight of his arm like an accusation.

I should have felt guilty. I wanted to feel guilty. Guilt would have been normal, would have been proof that I was still the person I'd always been. But when I searched for it, all I found was a low, constant hum of excitement that had been building since I'd driven away from the tennis club yesterday afternoon.

Jason stirred, pulling me closer in his sleep I felt nothing but impatience for him to leave.

By one-thirty, I was dressed. The tennis dress again, the white one with the small pleats that fell mid-thigh. I'd shaved everywhere this time, had spent twenty minutes on my hair even though I knew it would end up in a ponytail. I'd put on the matching pink underwear again as I looked at myself in the mirror, I felt a flutter of something that might have been nerves or might have been desire. They felt the same now.

I arrived at the club at one-forty-five. Too early, but I couldn't stay home any longer. The main courts were busy today, the sound of balls hitting rackets echoing across the property. I walked past them following the path Isaiah had described, around the far side of the clubhouse to where the hedge grew taller and thicker, blocking out the sight of everything but the private court beyond.

It was more isolated than I'd expected. Surrounded on three sides by dense greenery, the fourth side opening onto a view of the hills beyond the corporate park. No one could see in from the main courts or the parking lot. We would be completely alone.

Isaiah was already there, setting up a ball machine at one end of the court. He turned when he heard my footsteps I watched his eyes move over me, taking in the dress, the way I'd left my hair down, the subtle makeup I'd applied. His expression shifted, darkened with something that made my breath catch.

"You came," he said.

"Did you think I wouldn't?"

"I thought you might change your mind. Decide to be sensible." He walked toward me slowly I noticed he was wearing black athletic shorts again and a thin white tank that showed the definition of his shoulders and arms. "I'm glad you're not sensible."

I stepped onto the court feeling the clay give slightly beneath my shoes. "I don't think I know how to be anymore."

"Good." He stopped in front of me, close enough that I could smell him, clean sweat and something darker, something that made me want to lean in. "Because I've been thinking about you in that dress for twenty-four hours."

My heart was hammering so hard I thought he must be able to hear it. "What is it about?"

"You know what it's about." His hand came up, fingers grazing the strap of my dress where it rested on my shoulder. Just that light touch I felt it everywhere. "It's about the fact that you drove here today knowing exactly what was going to happen. It's about the fact that you want it to happen."

I couldn't deny it. Didn't want to deny it. "Yes."

"Yes what?"

"Yes, I want it."

His fingers tightened on my shoulder I saw his control waver. "Say it clearly. So there's no confusion."

I met his eyes and the words came out steady despite the way my pulse was racing. "I want you to touch me." I coughed and nearly choked on my own words.

For a moment, he didn't move. Then his hand slid from my shoulder down my arm, his palm warm and slightly rough against my skin. He took my hand and lifted it, pressing my palm flat against his chest. I could feel his heartbeat, rapid and strong.

"I've been thinking about touching you since you walked onto my court yesterday," he said quietly. "Thinking about what you'd feel like. How you'd respond." His free hand settled on my waist, his thumb stroking the curve of my hip through the thin fabric. "I think you'd respond beautifully."

"Isaiah. . . ."

"I think you'd surprise yourself." His hand moved from my waist to my lower back, pulling me closer. Not quite against him, but close enough that I could feel the heat radiating from his body. "I think you want to surprise yourself. That's why you're here."

He was right. That was exactly why I was here. To discover this version of myself that had emerged two days ago, bold and reckless and utterly unfamiliar. To see how far she would go.

"Show me," I whispered.

His eyes darkened. "Show you what?"

"What you've been thinking about."

His hand tightened on my back and for a moment I thought he would pull me fully against him, would kiss me right there in the bright afternoon sunlight. Instead, he stepped back and I felt the loss of his touch like a physical ache.

"Not yet," he said, his voice rough. "First, I want to watch you."

"Watch me what?"

"Play." He walked to the ball machine and switched it on. "I want to watch you move. I want to watch you get breathless. I want to see what you look like when you stop thinking and just feel it." He turned back to me, his expression dark with intent. "And then I'm going to touch you the way I've been imagining it for two days."

The machine began firing balls at a slow, steady pace. I moved into position, my whole body trembling with anticipation and something deeper, something that felt like hunger. I swung at the first ball and missed completely, too distracted by the way Isaiah was watching me.

"Focus," he called. "Eyes on the ball."

I tried to focus but I could feel his gaze on me, tracking every movement. The next ball came and I hit it cleanly, the impact reverberating up my arm. The sensation was sharper today, more visceral. Everything felt heightened, electric.

"Better," Isaiah said. "Again."

I hit the next ball then the next, falling into a rhythm. The dress swayed with each movement, the pleats lifting to show more of my thighs. I knew he was watching. I could feel the weight of his attention like a physical touch, but instead of making me self-conscious, it made me bolder. I put more force into each swing, moved more aggressively, let the dress fly higher.

"Christ," I heard him mutter. The rough edge in his voice sent heat pooling low in my stomach.

After a few minutes, he turned off the machine and walked onto the court. I was breathing hard, a light sheen of sweat on my skin despite the breeze. He circled me slowly I stood still, letting him look.

"You're beautiful when you move," he said. "You know that?"

I shook my head. "I'm not. . . ."

"Yes, you are." He stopped in front of me, his eyes intense. "And you know it. That's what's driving me crazy. You're standing here in this dress,

breathing hard, looking at me like that you know exactly what you're doing."

"What am I doing?"

"You're making me want to forget every reason why I shouldn't touch you." His hand came up, fingers brushing against my throat, feeling my pulse race beneath his touch. "You're making me want to find out if you taste as good as I think you do."

My breath caught. "And do you? Want that?" I was getting very bold.

"What do you think?" His thumb stroked the hollow at the base of my throat and I felt my eyes start to close. "I've been hard since you walked onto this court. Since yesterday, if I'm honest. You do that to me."

The bluntness of it shocked me. Jason never talked like that, never said things so directly. But Isaiah wasn't Jason. The raw honesty in his words made something clench deep inside me.

"I don't. . . ." I started, then stopped, because I didn't know how to finish that sentence. I didn't know anything anymore except that I wanted his hands on me, wanted to feel something other than the careful, predictable pleasure I'd always known.

"You don't what?" His hand slid from my throat to my collarbone, his fingers tracing the neckline of my dress. "You don't know what to say? Or you don't want to admit what you're thinking?"

"Both."

He smiled, slow and dangerous. "Let me help you. You're thinking about what it would feel like if I kissed you. You're wondering if it would be different than with him. Better." His fingers dipped lower, following the edge of the fabric. "You're wondering how far you'll let this go."

Every word was true. Hearing him say it out loud made it more real, more inevitable. I nodded, unable to speak.

"I'm going to kiss you," he said quietly. "And you're going to let me. And then we're going to find out exactly how far you want this to go." His hand moved to cup the side of my face, his thumb brushing across my lower lip. "But first, I need to hear you say it. I need to hear you tell me you want this."

My whole body was trembling now, every nerve ending alive with anticipation. "I want this."

"Say my name."

"Isaiah." My voice was barely a whisper. "I want you to kiss me."

He exhaled slowly, his control visibly fraying. Then his other hand came up to frame my face. He tilted my head back and I watched him lower his mouth to mine with agonizing slowness, giving me every opportunity to change my mind, to pull away.

But I didn't pull away like I thought I would, like I thought the woman I was must.

His lips touched mine, soft at first, almost tentative. Then he made a low sound in his throat and deepened the kiss, his mouth moving over mine with a confidence that made my knees weak. He kissed me the way he'd watched me, with complete attention, like there was nothing else in the world but this moment. His tongue traced the seam of my lips that I opened for him without thought, without hesitation.

The kiss turned hungry. He pulled me against him fully now. I felt the hard length of his body against mine, felt the evidence of what he'd said pressed against my stomach. His hands moved from my face to my hair, tangling in the strands, angling my head for better access. I made a sound I didn't recognize, something between a whimper and a moan and felt him smile against my mouth.

"That's it," he murmured between kisses. "Let me hear you."

His mouth moved to my jaw, my throat, finding sensitive spots I didn't know I had. Every touch of his lips sent sparks racing through me, building heat that gathered between my thighs. My hands clutched at his shoulders, needing something to hold onto. I felt the flex of muscle beneath my palms.

"You taste better than I imagined," he said against my neck, his breath hot on my skin. "And I imagined it a lot."

"Isaiah. . . ." His name came out as a gasp as his teeth grazed the spot where my neck met my shoulder.

"Tell me what you want." His hands moved down my back, over the curve of my hips, lower. "Tell me how far you want this to go baby."

I couldn't think. Could barely breathe. His hands were on the backs of my thighs now, his fingers brushing the hem of my dress. I felt myself trembling with the effort of staying upright.

"I don't know," I managed. "I've never. . . ."

"Never what?" He pulled back just enough to look at me. I saw my own desire reflected in his eyes. "Never done this before? Never cheated?"

The word hung between us, sharp and undeniable. That was what this was. That was what I was doing. And still, I couldn't make myself care the

way I should have.

"No," I whispered.

"But you want to." His hands slid higher, beneath the hem of my dress now, his palms hot against my bare thighs. "You want me to touch you. To make you feel things you've never felt before."

"Yes."

"Where?" His fingers traced patterns on my inner thighs, moving higher with excruciating slowness. "Where do you want me to touch you, Claire?"

I couldn't say it but he knew damn well where. I couldn't make myself form the words. But my body answered for me, my legs parting, my hips tilting toward his touch in shameless invitation.

"Here?" His fingers brushed against the edge of my underwear. I gasped. "Is this where you want me?"

"Please. . . ."

"Please what?" He pressed closer, his fingers moving in slow circles that didn't quite touch where I needed them to. "I want to hear you say it."

"Touch me," I breathed. "Please, Isaiah, I need. . . ."

His mouth crashed against mine, swallowing whatever I'd been about to say. His hand moved higher, pressing against me through the thin fabric of my underwear. I felt myself dissolve into sensation. He stroked me slowly, surely. I realized with distant shock that I was already wet, already ready for more than I'd ever intended.

"Christ, Claire," he groaned against my mouth. "You're soaked. All from just kissing?"

I couldn't answer, could only cling to him as his fingers moved with maddening skill, creating friction that made me see stars. He was supporting most of my weight now, one arm around my waist while his other hand worked between my thighs. I felt myself climbing toward something that felt both familiar and completely foreign.

Then his phone buzzed. Once, then again, insistent. He froze, his hand stilling we both stood there breathing hard.

"Fuck," he muttered, pulling his phone from his pocket with his free hand. His other hand was still between my thighs, still touching me. I felt myself clench around nothing. He looked at the screen and cursed again. "I have a lesson in ten minutes. Client's already here."

"Oh." Reality came crashing back. We were on a tennis court. In daylight. Anyone could have walked around that hedge and seen us.

He must have seen the panic in my eyes because his hand on my thigh tightened, holding me steady. "Hey. Look at me."

I met his gaze.

"This isn't over," he said firmly. "You understand? We're just beginning."

I nodded, not trusting my voice.

Slowly, reluctantly, he withdrew his hand from beneath my dress. The loss of contact made me want to whimper. He brought his fingers to his mouth. I watched in shock as he sucked them clean, his eyes never leaving mine.

"Next time," he said, his voice dark with promise. . . . "I'm going to taste you properly. And next time, there won't be any interruptions." He kissed me once more, hard and possessive. "Tomorrow. Same time. Don't even think about not showing up."

Then he stepped back, adjusting himself with a grimace and walked toward the gate. At the entrance to the court, he turned back.

"Claire?"

"Yes?"

"Wear a skirt. An easy one."

He left before I could respond. I stood alone on the private court, my body still humming with unfulfilled need, my underwear damp, my lips swollen from his kisses. I pressed my hand against my stomach, trying to steady my breathing and felt my phone buzz in my bag.

Jason. *Working late tonight. Order yourself something good for dinner. Love you.*

I stared at the message for a long time. Then I deleted it and walked on shaking legs back to my car, knowing with absolute certainty that tomorrow at two o'clock, I would be back. And this time, I would let Isaiah finish what he'd started.

I couldn't eat dinner. Couldn't focus on anything. Jason came home after eleven, exhausted from his late shift and fell asleep within minutes of getting into bed. I lay awake beside him for hours, my body still humming with the memory of Isaiah's hands on me, his fingers between my thighs, the raw hunger in his voice when he'd told me what he wanted to do next.

I'd never felt like this before. Never felt this constant, aching need that seemed to have taken up residence in my body. Every time I shifted, I felt the sensitivity between my legs, a reminder of how close I'd come to

something I'd never experienced. Jason stirred beside me, his hand landing on my hip and I had to bite back a sound because even that innocent touch felt overwhelming in my current state.

At three in the morning, I gave up on sleep and went to the bathroom. I looked at myself in the mirror, disheveled hair, flushed cheeks, pupils still dilated and barely recognized the woman staring back. I looked like someone who'd been thoroughly kissed. Like someone who'd been touched and left wanting more.

I pressed my thighs together, trying to ease the ache that had been building since Isaiah had walked away and felt my body respond immediately. I could take care of this myself. Could find release in the shower or back in bed beside my sleeping boyfriend. But something stopped me. Some instinct that told me this feeling, this desperate wanting, was meant to be drawn out. Savored. That the anticipation itself was part of what made this so intense. That the wrongness of it was what made it so good. I couldn't help grinning at the floor.

I went back to bed and lay there in the dark, letting myself remember every detail. The way Isaiah had pulled me against him. The roughness of his hands on my thighs. The shocking intimacy of watching him taste his fingers after touching me. And tomorrow, today now, technically, he would do more. He would finish what he'd started. He promised he would.

The thought made my stomach clench with something that was equal parts fear and desperate anticipation.

By morning, I was wound so tight I felt like I was going to shatter. Jason noticed something was off over breakfast, kept asking if I was feeling okay, if something was wrong. I told him I hadn't slept well. It wasn't a lie, exactly. He suggested I take a nap, maybe skip my plans for the day I had to physically stop myself from laughing at the irony.

"I'll be fine," I told him. "I'm just going to run some errands."

"Errands" had become my standard excuse. He never asked for details, never questioned where I went or how long I was gone. His trust in me was absolute, uncomplicated. It should have made me feel guilty. Instead, it just made everything easier.

I waited until he left for work, then went to my closet. I had a navy blue skirt, a soft cotton one that buttoned up the front. It fell to mid-thigh, perfectly appropriate for a tennis club. Perfectly innocent.

Except Isaiah had told me to wear an easy one.

Easy to what? I knew what. Easy to remove. Easy to push up. Easy to access.

My hands shook slightly as I put it on, paired it with a simple white tank top. No bra this time. The decision felt bold, reckless and I watched my reflection as I fastened the buttons, seeing the way the fabric clung to my braless breasts, showing more than I usually would. Matching blue underwear, though I had the sudden realization that they probably wouldn't stay on very long.

The thought made my knees weak.

I arrived at the club at one-thirty again, unable to wait any longer. The main courts were quiet today, most of the members at work or inside escaping the midday heat. I walked the familiar path to the private court, my heart pounding so hard I could feel it in my throat.

Isaiah was already there. He was sitting on the bench, elbows on his knees and he looked up when he heard me approach. The intensity in his eyes made me stop walking.

"You're early," he said.

"So are you."

"I've been here since one." He stood, his eyes moving over me in a way that made me feel naked despite being fully clothed. "Couldn't focus on anything else." He walked toward me slowly and I saw the tension in his shoulders, the barely controlled restraint in his movements. "Nice skirt."

"You told me to wear one."

"I did." He stopped in front of me, close enough that I had to tilt my head back. "You do everything I tell you to do, Claire?"

The question hung between us, loaded with implication. "I don't know yet."

His hand came up to touch my face, his thumb tracing my lower lip. "I thought about kissing you all night. Couldn't sleep. Kept thinking about how you sounded when I touched you. How wet you were." His thumb pressed against my lip and I opened my mouth instinctively. "That's going to drive me crazy, you know. How responsive you are."

I couldn't speak with his thumb in my mouth, could only stand there as he explored, his eyes darkening as I sucked without thinking.

"Fuck," he breathed, withdrawing his hand. "We need to slow down or this is going to be over before it starts."

"I don't want to slow down."

"Claire. . . ."

"I've been thinking about you since yesterday." The words came out in a rush, bold and honest. "I couldn't sleep. Couldn't think about anything else. I don't want to go slow. I want. . . ." I stopped, suddenly shy despite everything we'd already done.

"What do you want?" He stepped closer, his body nearly touching mine. "Tell me."

"I want you to finish what you started. I want to know what it feels like when you. . . ." I couldn't say it.

"When I make you come?" He said it so casually, so matter-of-factly, that I felt heat flood my face. "You can't even say it, but you want me to do it."

"Yes."

"Has Jason ever made you come?"

The question shocked me. "That's. . . ."

"Answer me." His hand settled on my hip, his fingers finding the hem of my skirt. "Has he?"

"Yes. Of course he has."

"How many times?"

I stared at him, confused by the question. "I don't know. We've been together two years. . . ."

"No." His hand slid higher, beneath my skirt now, his palm hot against my thigh. "I mean how many times in one session. When you're together, how many times does he make you come before he's done?"

I felt my face burn. "Once. Maybe once."

"Maybe?" His fingers traced patterns on my inner thigh, moving higher. "So sometimes not at all?"

"Sometimes it takes too long and he. . . ." I broke off, humiliated.

"He finishes first." Isaiah's expression hardened. "And then what? He rolls over and goes to sleep?"

"It's not like that. . . ."

"Isn't it?" His hand moved higher still I felt my legs part involuntarily for him. "You're standing here so desperate for me to touch you that you're shaking. When's the last time Jason made you feel like this?"

Never. The answer was never. But I couldn't say that out loud.

"That's what I thought." His fingers finally reached the edge of my underwear I gasped. "I'm going to make you come at least three times today, Claire. And you're going to remember every single one. You're going

to go home to him tonight and remember how I made you feel and you're going to realize what you've been missing."

"Isaiah. . . ."

"And then you're going to come back here tomorrow and we're going to do it again." He pressed against me through the fabric and my knees buckled. He caught me with his other arm, holding me upright. "You're already so wet. Were you like this all night?"

I nodded, beyond shame now.

"Did you touch yourself?"

"No."

"Why not?"

"I wanted. . . ." I gasped as his fingers moved in slow circles. "I wanted to wait. For you."

He made a sound low in his throat, something between a groan and a growl. "You're going to kill me." His mouth found mine, kissing me deeply while his hand worked between my thighs. "Tell me if you want me to stop. Tell me right now if this is too far."

I grabbed his wrist, but not to pull his hand away. To hold it in place. "Don't stop. Please don't stop."

He kissed me harder, his tongue sweeping into my mouth as his fingers slipped beneath my underwear. The first touch of his bare hand against my bare flesh made me cry out into his mouth. He stroked me slowly, learning the shape of me, finding what made me gasp and what made me moan.

"Christ, you're soaking again," he muttered against my lips. "How are you this turned on?"

"You. . . ." I couldn't form coherent thoughts. "It's you. The way you, oh god. . . ."

His fingers found my entrance, circling it teasingly. "The way I what?"

"The way you look at me. Touch me. Like you. . . ." I broke off as one finger slid inside me, slow and deliberate.

"Like I what?" He added a second finger and I felt myself stretch around him, felt the exquisite pressure. "Like I want to devour you? Like I've been thinking about this for days?" He began moving his fingers in and out, setting a rhythm that made me see stars. "Like I want to make you forget every other man you've ever been with?"

"Yes." The word came out as a sob. "All of that."

His thumb found my clit and the dual sensation of his fingers inside me and his thumb circling that sensitive bundle of nerves made my vision blur. I clung to him, my nails digging into his shoulders, my hips moving in time with his hand.

"That's it," he encouraged, his voice rough. "Take what you need. Use my hand. I want to watch you fall apart."

I'd never felt anything like this. Jason touched me carefully, tentatively, always asking if something was okay, if it felt good. Isaiah touched me like he owned me, like he knew exactly what my body needed and was going to give it to me whether I asked for it or not. The confidence in his touch, the certainty, made something inside me unravel.

"Isaiah. . . ." I gasped. "I'm close. I'm so close."

"I know. I can feel it. You're getting tighter around my fingers." He increased his pace, his thumb pressing harder. "Let go, Claire. Come for me. Let me feel it."

The orgasm hit me like a wave, sudden and overwhelming. My whole body went rigid, then convulsed, pleasure radiating out from where his hand was still working between my thighs. I cried out, the sound raw and unrestrained and I felt him hold me tighter as I shook against him.

"Beautiful," he murmured, his fingers still moving, drawing out every last tremor. "So fucking beautiful when you come."

I sagged against him, my legs unable to support me. He withdrew his hand slowly and I whimpered at the loss. Then he was lifting me, carrying me to the bench, sitting down with me in his lap. I buried my face against his neck, trying to catch my breath, trying to process what had just happened.

"That's one," he said softly, his hand stroking my back.

I pulled back to look at him. "One?"

"I told you. Three times, minimum." His eyes were dark, hungry. "And we're just getting started."

His hand moved to the buttons of my skirt and I watched as he unfastened them one by one, slowly revealing more of my thighs, my hips, my underwear. When the last button was undone, he pushed the fabric aside and looked down at me with an expression that made my stomach clench.

"Take them off," he said quietly, his fingers hooking into the waistband of my underwear.

I lifted my hips and let him slide them down my legs. He tossed them onto the bench beside us and suddenly I was sitting in his lap with my skirt open, completely exposed. The vulnerability should have terrified me. Instead, it made me feel powerful. Wanted.

"Spread your legs," he instructed.

I did, draping them over his thighs so I was open to his gaze, to his touch. He looked down at me, his jaw tight and I saw his hands flex like he was fighting for control.

"You're going to be the death of me," he said roughly. Then his hand moved between my thighs again I gasped at the sensitivity. "Still so wet. You liked coming for me, didn't you?"

"Yes."

"You want to do it again?"

"Yes." I was already moving against his hand, shameless in my need. "Please, Isaiah."

"I love hearing you beg." His fingers slid inside me again, easier this time he set a faster pace. "But next time, I want to taste you when you come. I want my mouth on you. Would you like that?"

The image his words conjured made me moan. "Yes."

"Yes what?"

"Yes, I want your mouth on me."

"Where?" His fingers curled inside me, hitting a spot that made me arch. "Be specific."

"I want. . . ." I couldn't believe I was saying this. "I want your mouth on my muffin. I want you to taste me."

"Fuck." His control slipped, his movements becoming rougher, more urgent. "You're going to make me come in my pants if you keep talking like that."

The thought of affecting him that much, of making him lose control, sent a thrill through me. I reached down and pressed my hand over his, making him go deeper, faster. "Then lose control. I want to see what I do to you."

He groaned, his free hand gripping my hip hard enough to bruise. "Claire, I'm trying to take my time with you. Trying to make this good."

"It is good. It's incredible." I was climbing again, faster this time. "But I don't want you controlled. I want you as desperate as I am."

Something in him snapped. He stood abruptly, taking me with him and I gasped as he set me on the bench and dropped to his knees between my

legs. His hands pushed my thighs apart, hooked my knees over his shoulders roughly, and then his mouth was on me.

The sensation was so intense I nearly screamed. His tongue found my clit immediately, circling it with maddening skill while his fingers continued their rhythm inside me. I grabbed his head, my fingers tangling in his hair and he groaned against me, the vibration adding another layer of pleasure.

"Isaiah, oh god, Isaiah. . . ."

He pulled back just enough to speak. "Pull my hair. I want to feel it."

I tightened my grip and felt him smile against me before his mouth returned with renewed intensity. He was relentless, using his tongue and fingers in perfect synchronization and I felt myself spiraling toward another orgasm with terrifying speed.

"That's it," he urged between strokes. "Come on my tongue. Let me taste it."

The combination of his words and his mouth pushed me over the edge. This orgasm was different from the first, sharper, more intense, radiating through my entire body. I screamed this time, not caring who might hear, my hips lifting off the bench as I came against his mouth.

He didn't stop. He kept licking, kept moving his fingers, drawing out the pleasure until I was sobbing with the intensity of it. When I finally came back to myself, I realized I was shaking, tears streaming down my face from the overwhelming sensation.

Isaiah stood, his chin wet with evidence of what he'd done pulled me into his arms. "That's two," he said softly, kissing my temple. "You okay?"

I nodded against his chest, unable to form words. My whole body felt like liquid, boneless and sated in a way I'd never experienced. But even through the haze of satisfaction, I could feel his hardness pressed against my stomach, could sense his tension.

"What about you?" I managed to ask.

"Don't worry about me."

"But you didn't. . . ."

"This isn't about me today." He tilted my face up, his expression serious. "Today is about showing you what you deserve. What you've been missing." His thumb brushed away a tear that had escaped. "Tomorrow, though. Tomorrow you're going to take care of me. And I'm going to teach you exactly how I like it."